Who you gon’ call? ‘Ghostbusters in Concert’

Eliza Huettl, Staff Writer



Kelly Tapia

There’s a slight chill descending upon UC San Diego. Is it the wind? Or something more … ghostly? “Ghostbusters in Concert” promised a thrilling immersive screening of the cult classic and delivered exactly that. Fans filed into the Epstein Family Amphitheater decked out in full ghostbusting garb and were greeted with two life-size movie replica vehicles — the perfect photo opportunity for longtime fans. On the stage itself was the big screen and the orchestra in concert-black uniform, ready to create an unforgettably ghoulish experience.

The orchestra’s performance was beautiful. There’s something magical about live music, a certain depth that is never captured in a recording. As everyone took their seats, conductor Danielle Jagelski introduced the orchestra members and each of their roles. She encouraged audience members to clap when beloved characters, such as Dana Barrett (Sigourney Weaver), came on screen. Under the glowing green amphitheater roof, “Ghostbusters” came to life.

The film opens following a librarian at work. The light, fluttery notes of the music indicate peace, but an underlying eerie, high-pitched tone creeps behind. As the oddities begin, the ringing becomes louder and more suspenseful. Once the ghostly apparition confronts the poor librarian, her scream transitions into the iconic upbeat “Who you gon’ call? Ghostbusters!” The blend of live instrumentals with the iconic eerie synthesizer demonstrates the artistry of the “Ghostbusters” soundtrack, both upbeat and haunting.

Nobody appreciates the “Ghostbusters” score quite like the people playing it. Xander Dawson, a recent graduate from the Berklee College of Music and flute player in the “Ghostbusters in Concert” orchestra, revealed in an interview with The UCSD Guardian that one of his personal favorite pieces from the score is “Dana’s Theme.” The track features a lovely, almost solemn intro that shifts into a more playful tempo. This theme reflects Dana’s character: She is solitary, refusing the initially unwanted advances from her suitors. The more playful notes show her sarcastic, independent and witty nature.



Photo by Kelly Tapia

Behind the curtain, touring a live orchestra is tricky. Dawson described his practicing process: “I’ll take a score, and I’ll find the most difficult passages to play, and I’ll attack those first. And then once I get comfortable with the music, I’ll just play through the entire movie.” The dedication these musicians put into their practice is evident during the performance, as every note played aligns perfectly with the visuals on screen.

Dawson also broke down how the orchestra keeps the elaborate show running: “[We] make sure that everything is lined up correctly with the movie. So while the audience is watching, they might just think they’re watching a simple movie, but it’s actually really precise down to the 10th of a beat sometimes or the 100th of a beat.”

To add extra whimsy, orchestra members changed into the iconic ghostbusting uniforms for the second half of the show. Beyond the music, “Ghostbusters in Concert” featured projected ghostly visuals that swept across the audience, immersing attendees further in the movie experience.

Beyond its special effects and live orchestra, what made “Ghostbusters in Concert” feel particularly remarkable were the audience members. Seeing die-hard fans of the franchise dressed up, taking pictures and meeting fellow fans made the experience feel all the more exciting. Through well-rehearsed music and impressive spectacle, “Ghostbusters in Concert” won me over as a first-time viewer.



Photo by Kelly Tapia